

Mating in the shallows

The adults return to shallow waters, near their nesting beaches, to find food and to breed. Males will fight for a female by latching onto each other. Turtles often have several mates.



The lost years

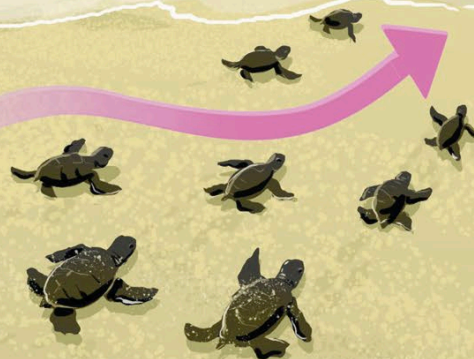
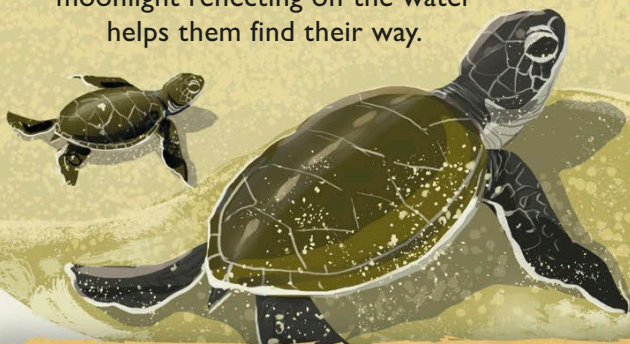
Once in the ocean, the surviving hatchlings seem to disappear. No one knows exactly where they go. This period of time is known as “the lost years.” The turtles take at least 25 years to mature before they start breeding.

Helpless babies

Baby sea turtles are very vulnerable to predators. Animals including land crabs, crocodiles, dogs, and sharks prey on the eggs and hatchlings.

To the ocean

Using their flippers as paddles, the baby turtles, called hatchlings, dig themselves out of the nest and scramble for the ocean. At night, the moonlight reflecting off the water helps them find their way.



Baby turtles are tiny—they are only about 2 in (5 cm) long.



Red-eared slider Like other freshwater turtles, the red-eared slider has clawed feet and a retractable head and limbs. The sea turtle has paddles instead of claws, and its body is streamlined for life in the ocean.



Sea kraits A type of snake, sea kraits spend most of their lives in the ocean but return to nesting sites on land to lay their eggs—just like sea turtles do.

